is interested in the results as free and fair elections didn't happen," he said.

Even so, Mamata's sway among the rural majority clearly holds because of her social welfare schemes, especially Lakshmir Bhandar, the monthly allowance for women. Loss of jobs caused by the Centre's withholding MNREGA funds have also hurt the BJP. But, mostly, voters were apprehensive of losing out on state benefits if there was a change of guard at the grassroots level.

However, even as celebratory fistfuls of green gulal coloured the air, TMC supremo and West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee maintained a studied silence for the large part. Bengal, after all, had grabbed national headlines not for the TMC's foretold success, but for the unimpeded bloodshed witnessed since the poll dates were announced on June 8. The toll is an index of how deep the culture of political violence runs here—25 people were killed since polling commenced; on July 8 itself, at least 18 people died. In all, 45 lives have been lost in a month. On July 8, violence became an instrument for the rampant electoral malpractices that were alleged. The day is said to have witnessed many instances of booth-capturing, rigging and destruction of ballot boxes. Entire villages were allegedly barricaded, candidates locked in, voters spooked by door-to-door intimidation and presiding officers attacked. Crude bombs were reportedly used with impunity, injuring hundreds. Nearly all the mayhem was blamed on the TMC by the Opposition, which the party vehemently denied.

Though 59,000 personnel of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) and other state forces were deployed at the direction of the Calcutta High Court, they were spread thin on the ground. In many booths, they were absent; in several sensitive areas, they reached after polling ended. While State Election Commissioner Rajiva Sinha blamed the Centre for sending the forces at the eleventh hour, thus hampering their effective deployment, the coordinator of the forces in Bengal, S.C. Budakoti, blamed the commission for not giving them complete and detailed locations of sensitive booths.

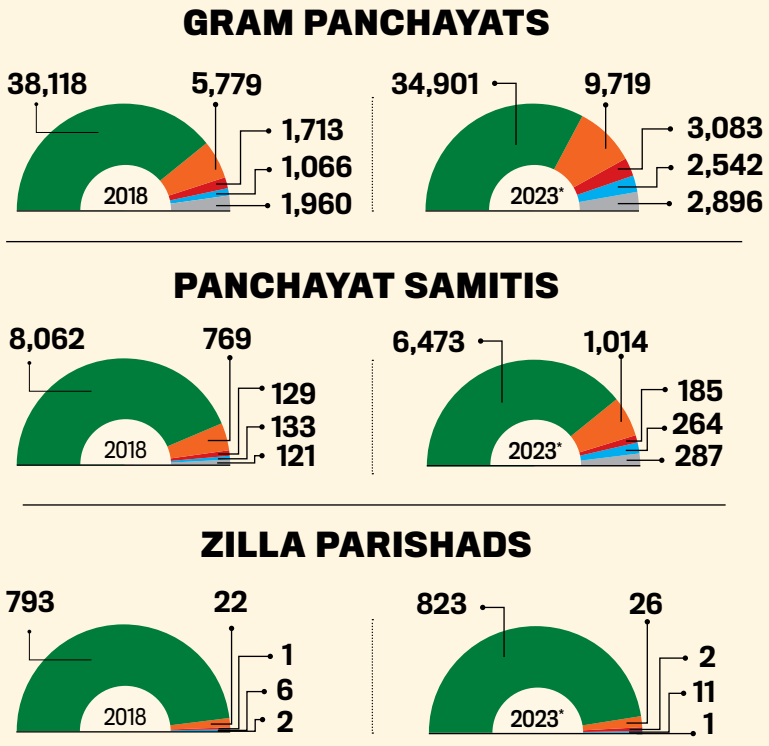
Bengal governor C.V. Ananda Bose, who had taken stock of the situation on the ground, submitted a report of the situation in Bengal to Union home minister Amit Shah in Delhi on July 9. Freely giving rein to his views on the alleged violence, he said, "The Bengal poll was a blot on the democratic fabric of India." Those lines were echoed, with added bite, by BJP spokesperson Sambit Patra on July 11, when he called the polls a "state-sponsored murder of democracy". Adhikari, who has been clamouring for President's rule in Bengal, convinced the party's central leadership to send a fact-finding team, to be convened by BJP leader Ravi Shankar Prasad, to probe the "TMC atrocities". On July 12, responding to PILs on the violence, the Calcutta HC held the SEC and the state responsible and said the future of the winners was dependent on its future orders.

With the poll results seen as a bellwether for the 2024 general election, TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee put out a triumphant tweet on July 11. "Grateful to people for converting Oppn's NO VOTE TO MAMATA TO NOW VOTE FOR MAMATA...paving the way for Lok Sabha elections," he wrote. Late on July 11, Mamata broke her silence on

EVEN IN ITS STRONGHOLDS LIKE NORTH BENGAL AND TRIBAL DISTRICTS LIKE BANKURA AND JHARGRAM, THE BJP HAS BEEN ROUTED BY THE TMC

A TMC SWEEP

The BJP, Left and Congress couldn't stop the TMC from an emphatic victory. This is how the 2023 result compares with that of the 2018 panchayat polls



*2023 panchayat poll results, as on July 12

Source: State Election Commission